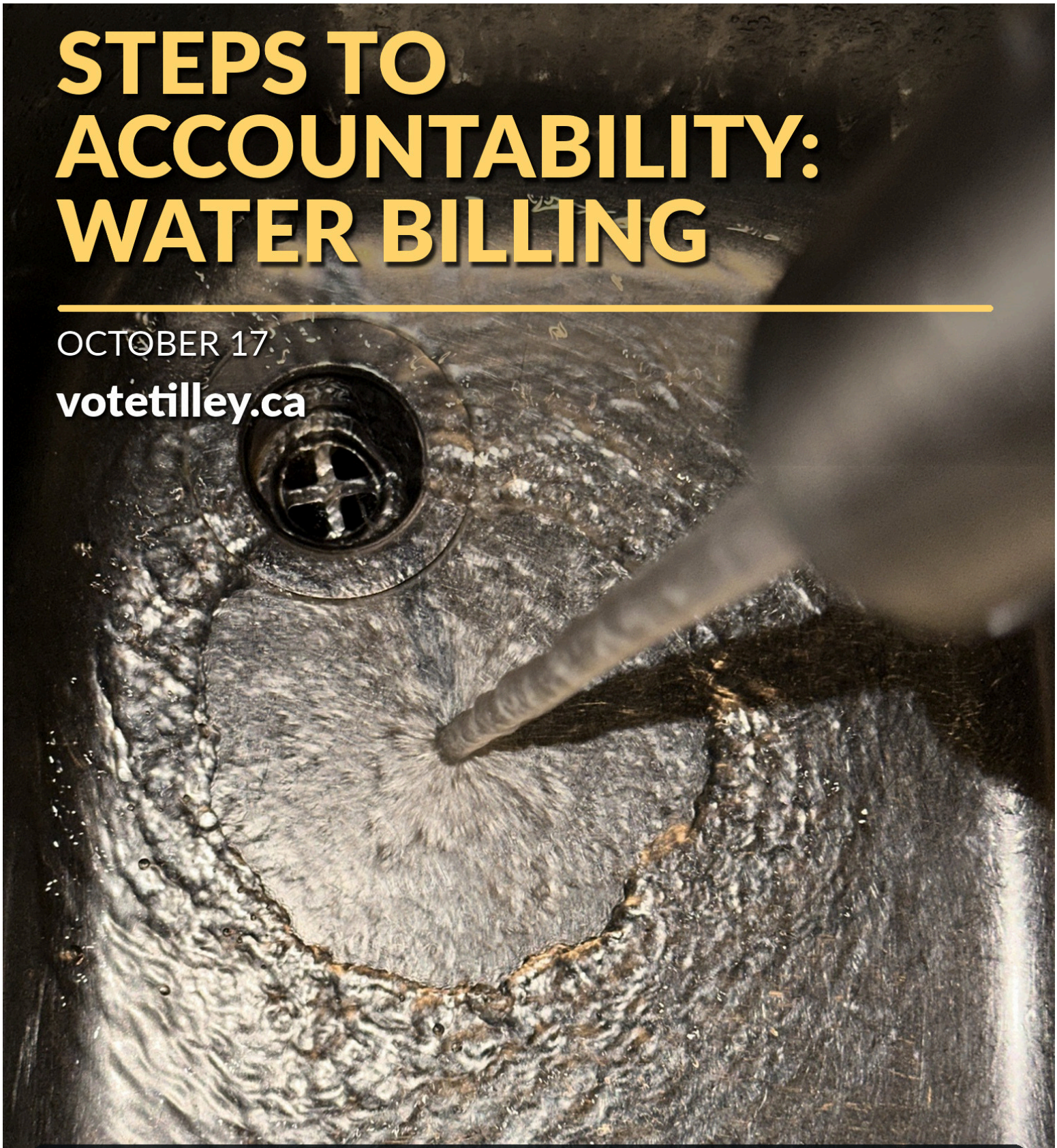
STEPS TO ACCOUNTABILITY: WATER BILLING

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80/20 IS A STARTING POINT, NOT THE FINISH

MEASURE • EVALUATE • REFINE

FAIR WATER BILLS • STABLE FINANCES

BOARD SETS OBJECTIVES • REPORTS RESULTS



October 15, 2026

Steps to Accountability: Water Billing

Making water billing more equitable: fairness, conservation and financial sustainability.

A mother raising a busy family recently shared her concerns about rising water costs and whether the SCRD's proposed billing system would treat families fairly.

Her concerns prompted me to examine the proposed rates, the assumptions behind them, and how other regional districts in BC manage water billing.

Are we using the right assumptions?

The SCRD's proposed 80/20 billing structure has a reasonable rationale. Recovering 80% of water user-fee revenue through fixed charges provides financial stability while residents adjust to consumption-based billing.

However, the proposed 46 m^3 quarterly allowance originated in Pender Harbour, using an estimated 270 litres per person daily and an average household size of 1.9 people.

Census data published by the SCRD itself reveals important differences:

- Pender Harbour/Egmont: 1.9 people per household
- Halfmoon Bay: 2.2
- Roberts Creek: 2.3
- Elphinstone: 2.4

Occupancy patterns differ too. The SCRD's 2024 Annual Report shows approximately 40% of dwellings in Area A had no usual residents, compared with 17% in Roberts Creek. Not all are necessarily seasonal homes, but these figures demonstrate important differences in year-round residency.

Applying the same estimated consumption to Roberts Creek's average household produces approximately 56 m^3 quarterly, rather than 46 m^3.

That doesn't establish the correct allowance, but it raises a legitimate question about applying assumptions developed for Pender Harbour to communities with different demographics.

Families deserve reasonable breathing room as we introduce this new billing system.

Understanding the financial constraints

Unlike municipalities, regional districts must maintain separate financial accounts and balanced plans for each service. Revenue collected for one service generally cannot simply subsidize another, although limited transfers are permitted under provincial legislation.

This makes the financial stability of the water service particularly important.

We must carefully balance three sources of funding:

Parcel taxes: Supporting infrastructure and system capacity.

Fixed user fees: Providing predictable revenue for ongoing service.

Volumetric charges: Reflecting actual consumption and encouraging conservation.

Other BC regional districts have adopted different approaches to balancing these costs. Their experiences demonstrate that there are workable alternatives, each with advantages and financial risks.

The challenge is finding the balance that works for our communities.

What should the next Board do?

The SCRD's initial 80/20 structure should be a starting point, not the permanent solution by default.

Importantly, the SCRD's 2026–2035 Water Efficiency Plan already commits to reviewing water rates for fairness and efficiency.

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What's missing is a clearly defined process with measurable objectives for progressively refining the billing structure, demonstrating improvements in equity, and managing financial risk.

This is what the next Board needs to establish.

We need a policy requiring an ongoing cycle of improvement:

1. **Measure:** Track consumption, conservation, operating costs, revenues and water losses.
2. **Evaluate:** Assess household affordability, equity and financial stability.
3. **Refine:** Adjust the balance between parcel taxation, fixed fees and volumetric charges, progressively strengthening consumption-based billing where justified.
4. **Report:** Publish annual findings, proposed adjustments and the reasons behind decisions.
5. **Repeat:** Continue improving the system as experience and evidence accumulate.

The SCRD's Water Efficiency Plan is scheduled for an update in late 2027. That presents an opportunity to formally establish these objectives and accountability measures.

The goal

Everyone should contribute fairly to maintaining our water infrastructure, while what they pay increasingly reflects the water they actually consume.

We don't need to design the perfect billing system today. We need to revisit the assumptions, give families a reasonable transition, and establish a policy that ensures continued improvement.

The SCRD must balance its financial risks with the real costs experienced by the people it serves.

The next Board's responsibility isn't simply to implement volumetric billing and move on. It's to establish clear objectives, monitor performance and ensure the system evolves toward greater equity without compromising financial sustainability.

That's accountability: establish objectives, measure results, make informed adjustments and keep improving.

The 80/20 structure should be the beginning of that process, not its completion.

Sources

- SCRD 2024 Housing Needs Report, Table 3, p. 22
- SCRD 2024 Annual Report, pp. 120–121
- SCRD 2026–2035 Water Efficiency Plan, Action B6
- BC Local Government Act, ss. 373–374